

By retaining the ministers for most of the portfolios in the government's third term, Modi is signalling continuity, reassuring stakeholders in each ministry

than 60 per cent belong to the underprivileged classes—27 of them from the Other Backward Classes (OBCs), 10 from the Scheduled Castes, five from the Scheduled Tribes and five from among the minorities, but no Muslim.

Modi and the BJP came in for some unexpected ticking-off by RSS (Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh) *sarsanghchalak* Mohan Bhagwat in a speech from the organisation's Nagpur headquarters on June 10. Expressing displeasure at the divisive discourse among political parties during the election, Bhagwat said, "The manner in which events have unfolded, with each side engaging in below-the-belt attacks, ignoring the divisive impact of campaign strategies and increasing social and mental fault lines, is concerning." He advised the new government to work on building a national consensus and not treat the Opposition as enemies of the state. Bhagwat indicated that he was unhappy with the Modi government's handling of the continuing crisis in Manipur. But it was Bhagwat's remark that a "true *sevak*" is one who does his task without taking pride in the accomplishment and is free of arrogance that hit home. The next day, Modi via his X handle, told all his supporters to remove the suffix "Modi *ka parivar*" from their handles, which they had been requested to add during the election. Soon after, there was a call for a review meeting of the BJP-RSS brass to ensure a greater coordination of purpose that had gone missing during Election 2024.

NOW FOR THE HARD PART

The real test for Modi, though, will be his ability to successfully overcome the various challenges that confront him in his third term. Chief among them is the state of the economy, which is being held as the primary reason for the BJP's underwhelming performance at the hustings. Despite India being among the world's fastest-growing large economies, clocking a GDP growth of above eight per cent, pre- as well as post-poll surveys have indicated that people were the most unhappy with the Modi government over two key issues—unemployment and inflation. Also, that India's young and aspirational millions, who constitute a majority of the working population, were no longer satisfied with doles but wanted to earn a decent living instead. Their version of the Great Indian Dream included being gainfully employed, having a concrete roof of their own over their heads, enough food to eat, potable water to drink, bathrooms in their houses, quality schools for their children, healthcare for their families and connectivity—in terms of both transport and communications. Ease of living, and not just being above the poverty line, was the new minimum. Modi's call for a Viksit Bharat (Developed India) by 2047 was a distant dream, citizens wanted a Sukhi and Surakshit Bharat (happy and secure) in the next five years and expected the Modi government to keep pace with their growing aspirations.

To his credit, Modi has in his preceding two terms ensured that the basic needs of most Indians, be it food, drinking water, sanitation and, to some extent, housing, were met, though there is immense scope for improvement in last-mile delivery. He has also introduced several far-reaching economic reforms such as the Goods & Services Tax (GST) and the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, which has helped clean up the non-performing assets of banks. He also drastically cut back corporate tax rates to stimulate private investment and spent massive sums of public money to build infrastructure. His prudent handling of the economy during and after the pandemic came in for universal praise. At the political level, the abrogation of Article 370, the construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya in addition to the partial implementation of the Uniform Civil Code with the criminalisation of triple talaq has brought a sense of closure, however controversial, to many of these vexatious issues.

That said, his decade-long tenure has had its fair share of setbacks. His attempt to reform agriculture met with strong farmers' opposition, forcing him to repeal the farm laws, land reforms remained a stillborn project, while his government's inability to boost the share of manufacturing beyond